SCHOOL OF ENGLISH
THE UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG

ENGL7995 CAPSTONE EXPERIENCE: THE HAPPINESS PROJECT

Semester: 2025-2026 Second Semester
Credits: 12
Contact hours: Weekly meetings with supervisors
Form of assessment: 100% coursework

Course Convenors:

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Course description:

This course will ask students to think of communication as an opportunity to generate an act of creative "happiness." This project-focused course culminates in the staging or exhibition of students' capstone projects that will centre around the theme of Happiness. This capstone course will ask students to think of their ongoing projects in terms of the ways in which human communities pursue happiness, and to consider their own creativity in the context of ideals, rituals, and play that facilitate human thriving. In this course, "happiness" is pursued not merely as a fleeting emotional state but as a foundational element in storytelling and design, intended to enrich the narrative's impact and resonance. Students are also invited to critique and challenge the ways in which Happiness is conventionally understood and defined. In the capstone process, students are invited to explore their personal vulnerability or resistance to certain "master plots" and conventions of their field, to challenge familiar and often unchallenged ideologies, and to become powerful players in their own acts of building and constructing creative communication that lasts through time.

Course objectives:

- To develop proficiency in translating conceptual projects into tangible, interactive exhibits that engage audiences effectively.
- To deepen students' understanding of the interplay between creativity and personal life stories in the development of their projects.
- To enhance abilities in crafting presentations that eloquently convey project narratives and inspire audience interest.
- To encourage critical examination of established narratives and ideologies within creative fields

Course learning outcomes (CLOs):

CLO 1: Demonstrate the ability to efficiently and effectively communicate complex creative ideas and narratives to target audiences.
CLO 2: Exhibit how creativity and personal life stories inform and shape collaborative projects and narratives.

CLO 3: Employ marketing, presentation, and exhibition skills adeptly to showcase projects.

CLO 4: Demonstrate the ability to critically challenge established narratives and ideologies, adapting or innovating within contemporary creative industries.

Course organisation:
This course includes the following student learning activities:

- Group project based regular meetings with supervisors
- Independent project development
- Group discussions and self-study
- Rehearsals and final showcase

Course teaching and learning activities:

	Activities	**Aligned course learning outcomes**
1	Weekly Supervisions: Regular meetings where supervisors guide students on preparing for the final presentation and exhibition, emphasising presentation techniques and effective communication strategies.	CLO1, CLO3,
2	Independent Study: Self-directed research and project development, applying theoretical knowledge to practical implementation.	CLO2, CLO4
3	Group Project Development: Collaborative project work where students integrate diverse creative ideas and personal narratives, enhancing project depth and breadth.	CLO2, CLO4
4	Rehearsals: Practice sessions for the final showcase where students refine their presentation skills and receive critical feedback from supervisors to perfect their exhibition techniques.	CLO1, CLO3,

	Activities	Aligned course learning outcomes
5	Final Showcase: A final presentation and exhibition where students demonstrate their comprehensive skills and creativity, synthesising course content and project work.	CLO1, CLO2, CLO3, CLO4

Assessment:

Assessment method	Brief description	Weighting (%)	Aligned course learning outcome(s)
Participation	Students must be actively engaged and contribute to course activities including weekly supervisions, group discussions, rehearsals, and the submission of brief progress reports, as well as other potential interactive sessions.	20%	CLO1. CLO3
Progress Report	A detailed report that outlines strategies and preparation steps for the final presentation and exhibition. This includes approaches to presenting the project, plans for the exhibition layout, handling of logistical aspects, and strategies to overcome anticipated challenges.	20%	CLO1, CLO3, CLO4
Final Presentation	Students work in groups to deliver a 10-minute presentation of their final capstone project during the showcase, emphasising their research, creative process, and outcomes. This presentation aims to effectively communicate with the audience.	30%	CLO1, CLO3, CLO 4
Final Exhibition	Complementary to the presentation, students exhibit their final projects in a professional setting. This includes demonstrating the practical application of their creative and theoretical work and may involve displaying necessary iterations, prototypes, or other props related to the project.	30%	CLO2, CLO3, CLO4

Key Dates and Deadlines:

Pre-Showcase Phase

Date	Event	Details
January 23, 2026	Submission of Project Information Survey	Noon submission. Small/individual teams: also email proposal to **longchiu@hku.hk** and **macchku@hku.hk** (2 pages max).
February 3, 2026	Site Visit and Introductory Session	Exact time to be confirmed
March 18, 2026	Brief Progress Report Due	500-700 words; 17:00 submission via Moodle + supervisor email (PDF)
April 1, 2026	Showcase Proposal and Equipment Application Due	Noon submission via Moodle; include Appendix A template with supporting design documents
April 8, 2026	Confirmation of Showcase Proposal and Equipment Application	Revisions to be submitted and confirmed by then
April 9, 2026	Progress Report Due	1000-1200 words; 17:00 submission via Moodle + supervisor email (PDF)
April 19-24, 2026	First Round Rehearsals	Dates/times set by supervisors; present latest exhibit drafts and presentation decks
May 3-10, 2026	Final Round Rehearsals	Exact times by supervisors; critical feedback and refinement sessions
Mid-May, 2026 (dates to be confirmed)	Happiness Showcase	Exact time to be confirmed

Showcase Phase

- Event days will be mid-May, 2026. Exact dates to be confirmed
- Attendance on all event days is mandatory; absence may result in course failure
- Students should not schedule travel or work commitments on event days
- Specific presentation times assigned per rundown
- Each group presents 10 minutes (strict cutoff)
- No student guest invitations

Plagiarism warning:

Definitions

The University's definitions on "plagiarism" are as follows:

Plagiarism refers to "direct copying of textual material or wilful use of other people's data and ideas, and presenting them as one's own without acknowledgement, whether or not such materials, data and ideas have been published" (Paragraph 6, HKU's "Regulations Governing Students' Academic Conduct Concerning Assessment"). In other words, a person is committing plagiarism if he/she paraphrases or quotes the work of another person without clearly identifying (according to academic conventions) the borrowed material and documenting its source.

Self-plagiarism refers to "reuse of one's own data or repeat of previously published written work, or part thereof, in a 'new' publication without acknowledging that the data set has been used or written work has been published elsewhere" (Paragraph 3.1, HKU's "Policy on Research Integrity"). For instance, if a student re-uses largely or fully the contents of his/her past assignment submitted elsewhere and without acknowledging so in the "new" assignment, it can constitute self-plagiarism.

Plagiarism is a very serious offence and it is strictly prohibited in all assignments and examinations: "A candidate shall not engage in plagiarism nor employ nor seek to employ any other unfair means at an examination or in any other form of assessment" (Paragraph 6, HKU's "Regulations Governing Students' Academic Conduct Concerning Assessment"). Students should use proper citations and provide sources wherever necessary.

Protocol on the Handling of Plagiarism

There are severe penalties for plagiarism in the School of English. Students found plagiarizing may be failed not only in the plagiarized oral or written assignment but in the course. Their case will also be considered by a School panel which may decide on further penalties depending on the gravity of the offence. This may involve disclosure of the plagiarism committed to teachers of other courses within the School. The panel may also decide to lodge a complaint with the University's Disciplinary Committee which can result in other penalties. For details, please refer to the "Protocol on the Handling of Plagiarism".

Guidelines

There are clear university guidelines in the "What Is Plagiarism" booklet. Students should read these guidelines carefully and revisit them from time to time, especially before submitting an assignment. Ignorance about the nature and definition of plagiarism is never an excuse and will not be accepted. The School of English prepared the "Guidelines for Citing and Documenting Sources" (PDF) for students to download.

Originality Checking of Assignments

Please read HKU's Turnitin webpage for information on this originality checking engine, which "offers originality checking on students' work for proper citation or potential plagiarism. Once a paper is submitted to Turnitin, it will compare with documents in a continuously updated database consisting of current and archived web pages, millions of student papers worldwide, and collections of newspapers, magazines, scholarly journals, e-Books and e-Texts".

Policy on Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence

As a general rule, the **uncited** use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) is strictly prohibited, and will be considered as plagiarism. Students who do choose to use AI to modify their assignments **must** keep a record of their interactions with the AI (e.g. any changes made to the assignment by the AI) and submit it along with the assignment as an Appendix. The AI should also be cited both in-text and in the Bibliography of the assignment. When in doubt about your usage, please consult with your course convenor.

Course grade descriptors:

A+, A, A-	Excellent result. A thorough grasp of the subject as demonstrated by original, creative or exceptionally astute analysis and synthesis of ideas or critical interpretation of texts/issues/other course content or reflection on learning experience. Ample evidence of familiarity with relevant reading and research as well as very effective organizational, rhetorical and presentation skills as appropriate to the assessment task. Students display excellent communication skills in areas such as grammar, vocabulary, oral and aural competencies.
B+, B, B-	Good to very good result. A good to very good grasp of the subject as demonstrated by generally persuasive analysis and synthesis of ideas or critical interpretation of texts/issues/other course content or reflection on learning experience. Some evidence of a generally sound understanding of relevant reading and research as well as effective organizational, rhetorical and presentation skills as appropriate to the assessment task. Students display good to very good communication skills in areas such as grammar, vocabulary, oral and aural competencies.
C+, C, C-	Satisfactory to reasonably good result. A reasonable grasp of the subject as demonstrated by some analysis of ideas or interpretation of texts/issues/other course content or reflection on learning experience. Familiarity with relevant reading and research is adequate but tends to be rather descriptive with little evidence of critical reflection but organizational, rhetorical and presentation skills, as appropriate to the assessment task, still contribute to overall coherence satisfactorily. Students display reasonable communication skills in areas such as grammar, vocabulary, oral and aural competencies.

D+, D	Barely satisfactory result. A minimal grasp of the subject with little analysis of ideas or critical interpretation of texts/issues/other course content or reflection on learning experience. Hardly any evidence of familiarity with relevant reading or research as required for the assessment task. Ideas presented are generally not well organized or well argued but still largely comprehensible. Students display minimal communication skills in areas such as grammar, vocabulary, oral and aural competencies.
F	Unsatisfactory result. A poor grasp of the subject with negligible or largely inaccurate analysis of ideas or interpretation of texts/issues/other course content or reflection on learning experience. A general lack of familiarity with relevant reading or research, as required for the assessment task. Work presented is poorly organized, largely irrelevant and incoherent. Work fails to reach the level expected for a master's curriculum. Students display poor communication skills in areas such as grammar, vocabulary, oral and aural competencies. Plagiarism or non-submission of coursework will also result in a Fail.

Points of contact:

For course-related enquiries, please contact the respective course instructors. Regarding assessment and any tutorial arrangements, please contact your tutor. Otherwise, your primary points of contact are:

Ms Hayley Wong, Executive Officer: hayleyhw@hku.hk

You can contact the officers via email: macchku@hku.hk (for MACC students).

If you face difficulties in using any of the Internet services, including the Moodle class site, please contact the Information Technology Services (ITS) (Email: ithelp@hku.hk; Tel: 3917 0123). Please visit the ITS web page for their opening hours.

In all email enquiries, please specify the course code and title, and include your full name, nickname (if applicable), and your programme (MACC/MFA).

Students are welcome to schedule appointments with the course instructors and tutors at any point during the semester. All appointments are expected to be scheduled by email.